

Can Chatbots Correct Election Misinformation?

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ARC Discovery Project 2023-27 "Mapping &
Harnessing Public Trust & Mistrust"

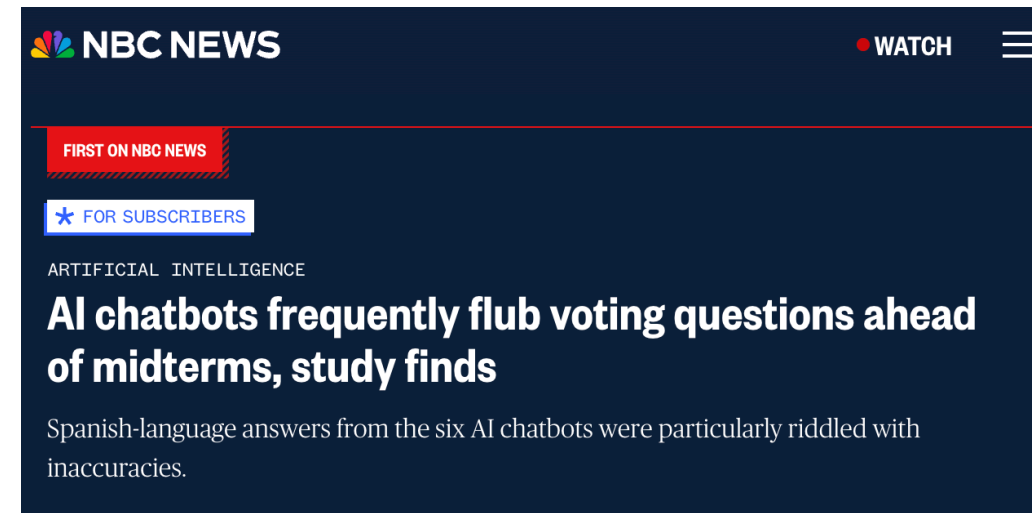
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AI has entered the election information environment

- From "*Google it*" to "*ask ChatGPT*": citizens increasingly use chatbots to search, summarise and interpret public information.
- However..., the same systems can reproduce hallucinated electoral claims or be seeded with falsehoods about voting procedures.

Can the same technology that (allegedly) amplifies election misinformation also help correct it?



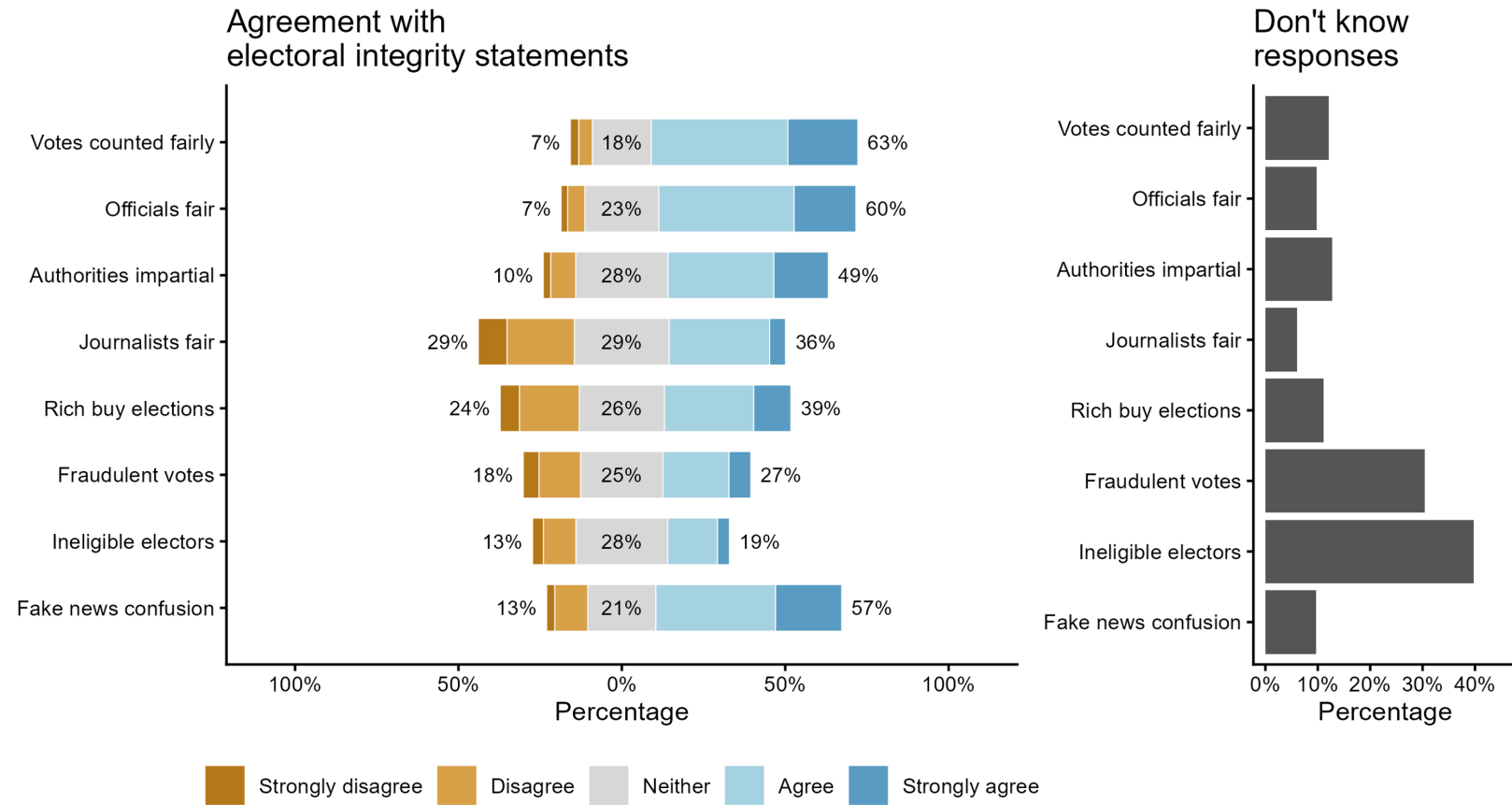
Australia is a hard test for corrective dialogue

- Australia has comparatively high trust in its national election administrator.
- **More than half** trust or strongly trust the AEC (Australian national EMB) in our ACVS survey (2025/26).
- It also reports **66%** trust or strongly trust in an APSC pulse survey (2026 Mar).
- High baseline trust could make large improvements ***harder to detect***.



Perceptions of electoral integrity are more varied

- Considerable uncertainty
- Concerns about information integrity



During the 2025 federal election, dozens of instances of misinformation has been documented:

Electoral process

Disinformation register

2025 Federal Election

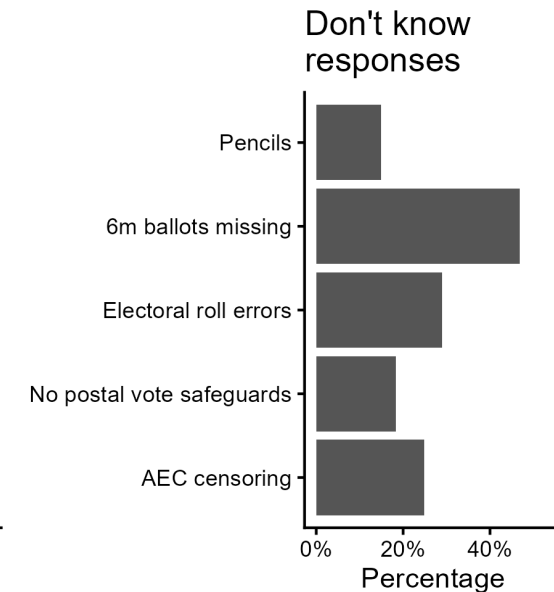
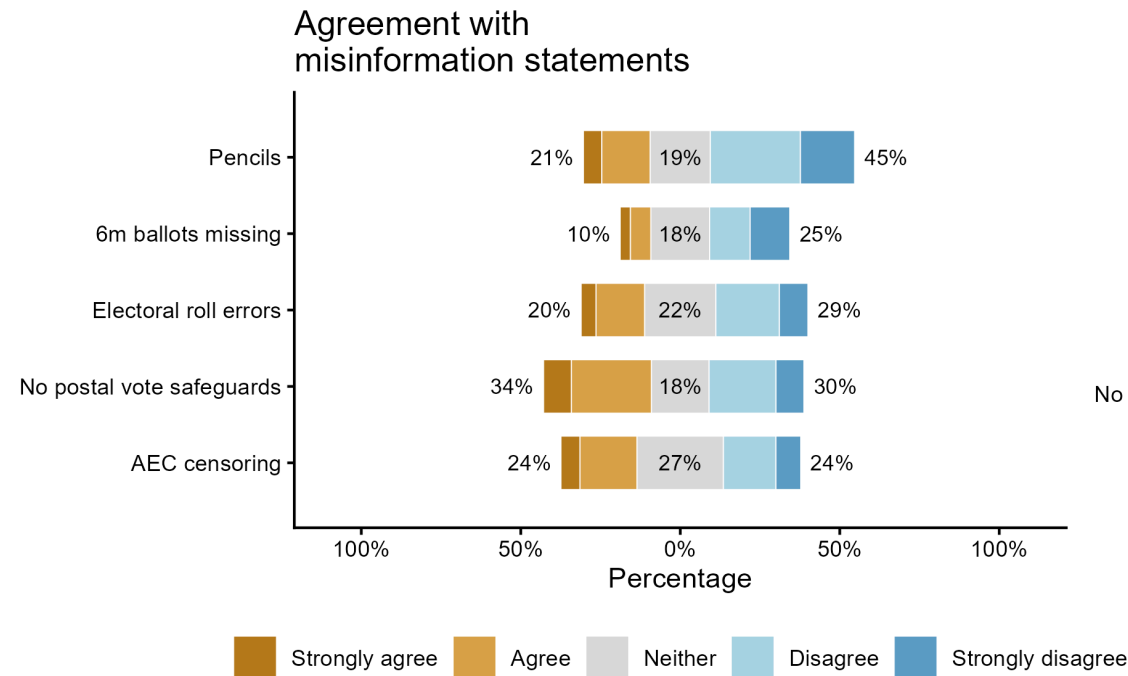
<https://www.aec.gov.au/media/disinformation-register-2025.htm>

-  **Disinformation**
Six million ballot papers went missing and weren't counted in the 2025 federal election. ✓
-  **Disinformation**
There are substantial inconsistencies or errors in the electoral roll that make voter fraud and 'vote rigging' easier. ✓
-  **Disinformation**
There is a formula to casting a 'Vote of No Confidence' (VONC) - people leave the ballot paper blank and instead write "no suitable candidate to meet my will". This can cause an election to be re-run if enough people cast their vote that way. ✓
-  **Disinformation**
A video circulated online shows an AEC polling official rubbing out votes marked with pencil. ✓
-  **Disinformation**
Prior to February 2025, the AEC has never attended citizenship ceremonies to enrol new citizens. ✓

Misinformation still had a foothold

Only **24-45%** rejected the misinformation narratives in our ACVS Wave 2 (2026 Mar).

In our later experiment, **59.4%** of respondents who expressed endorsement *at least one of the five claims*.



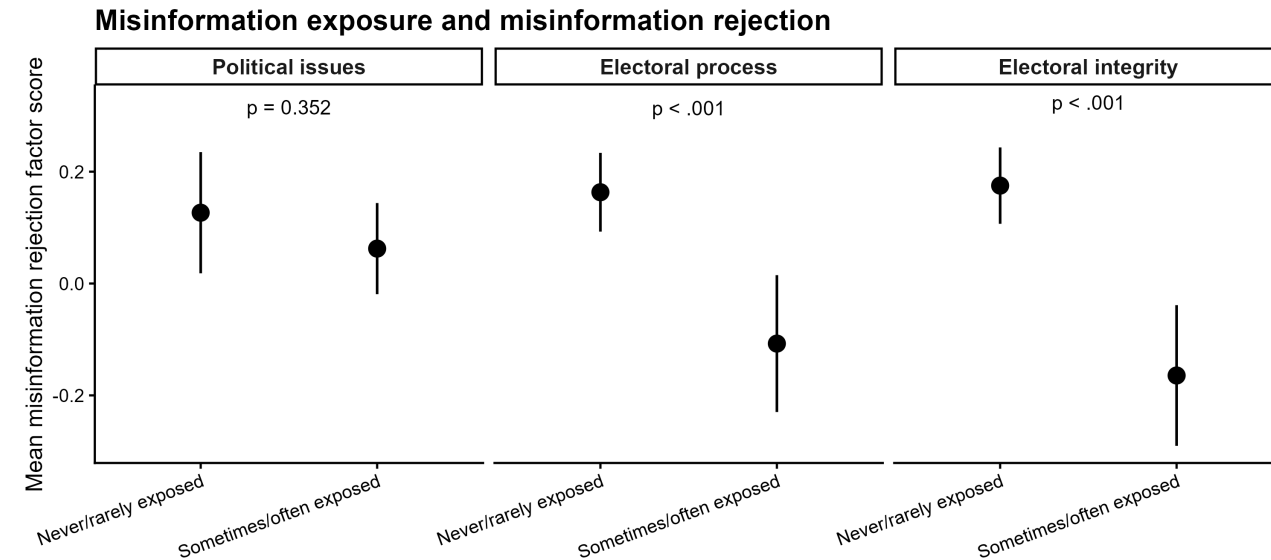
Electoral misinformation is procedural and institutional

- "Pencils are used so that votes can be rubbed out."
- "Six million ballot papers went missing and weren't counted."
- "There are substantial errors in the electoral roll that lead to voter fraud."
- "There are no safeguards to prevent fraud in postal voting."
- "The electoral authorities censor political debate by labelling it disinformation."

These are factual assertions, but they also invite judgment about competence, fairness and legitimacy of the EMB.

Perceived misinformation exposure correlates with actually-held misinformation beliefs.

- For integrity- or process-related misinformation the predicted likelihood of endorsing at least one election conspiracy rises from about 42-43% among those not exposed to 59-62% among those exposed ($p < .001$).



How to combat electoral misinformation?

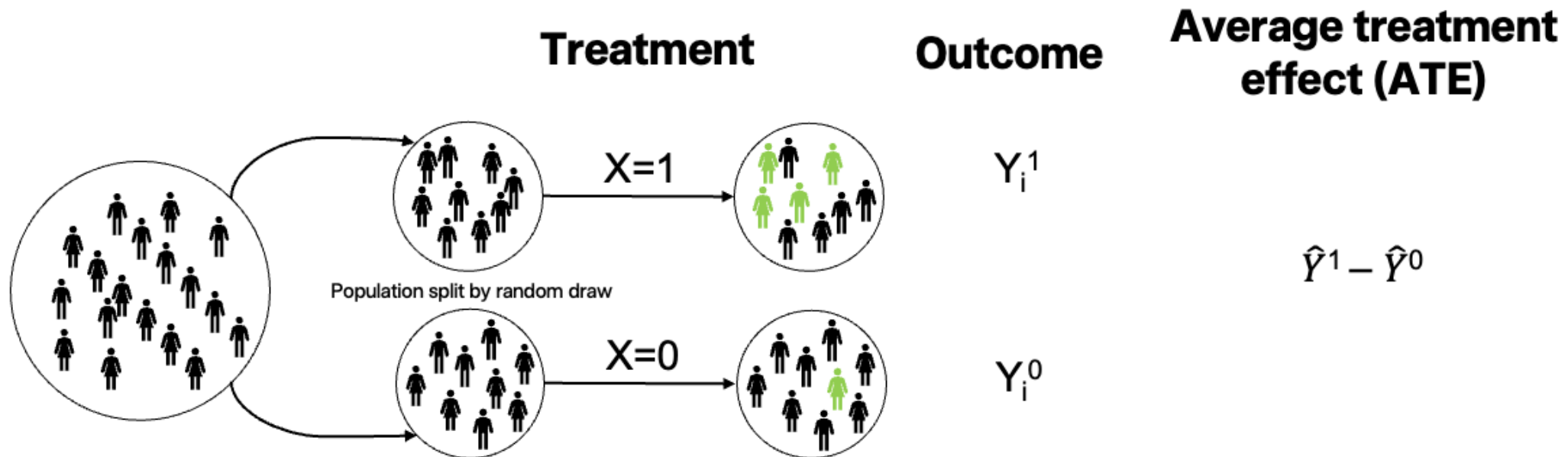
Level	Common response
Individual	Classical reasoning (fact-checking/debunking , prebunking, media literacy) Motivated reasoning (reducing identity threat, cognitive dissonance)
Platform	Content flagging and warning labels Forwarding/sharing restrictions Algorithmic changes to reduce misinformation exposure
Institutional	Dedicated misinformation coordination bodies / public resilience initiatives Regulation of platform misinformation responses

- Recent experimental studies suggest that **personalised, interactive AI chatbot dialogues can reduce misinformation belief** (Costello et al. 2024; Gong & Su 2025; Calabrese et al. (2026); Person et al. 2026)

Our question sits at the individual-institutional boundary: **can an election authority use dialogue to answer specific doubts, and furthermore, correct false assertions?**

Testing interventions

- **Study 1:** Factsheet and LLM dialogues, N = 1,602 (Mar 2026)
- **Study 2:** Targeted LLM debunking, N = 2,659 elections sceptics (Jul 2026)



Study 1: Factsheet and LLM dialogues, N = 1,602 (Mar 2026)

6 Conditions:

- Control
- Factsheet, unattributed
- Factsheet, attributed
- LLM chat, unattributed
- LLM chat, attributed
- LLM placebo

Factsheet

How the integrity of your vote is protected

Free and fair elections are the cornerstone of democracy. In recent federal elections in Australia, four key safeguards were used to uphold the integrity of your vote.

Integrity of the electoral roll

The federal electoral roll is the official list used to make sure that every citizen who should vote, does so – and that every citizen only votes once.

The roll is kept accurate through an Annual Roll Integrity Review (ARIR), which checks enrolment records against trusted external data to confirm voters' names, addresses and electoral divisions. Enrolment and updates can be completed online, and targeted direct enrolment is used to reach people missing from the roll. Identity is confirmed using documents such as a Medicare card or Australian citizenship papers.

Ballot security

Voters cast their vote in federal elections by completing an official printed ballot paper. There are layered safeguards to prevent fraudulent votes from being inserted and to protect ballot papers from any tampering or removal. Ballot papers are treated as "live" documents from the moment of printing until they are destroyed, up to 7 years after the election. Before and after they are distributed to polling stations, they are sealed in tamper-evident packaging, logged and tracked, and stored in secure locations. For complex counts, ballot papers are scanned and checked with additional verification steps to ensure voter intent is preserved, and so the count can always be checked and audited.

Postal vote security

Every federal election, many people apply to lodge postal votes because they cannot attend a polling station for work, health or other reasons, or will be away from home.

Postal vote applications are checked against the electoral roll, and each postal voting pack is linked to the specific voter. Voters must complete a postal vote certificate, and have it witnessed by another enrolled voter, who confirms the voter completed their own ballot papers. The certificate and ballot papers are returned in a sealed envelope, with the security information checked before the envelope is opened. Postal votes are then counted and tracked using the same security as for other ballot papers.

Disinformation response

During each federal election, a Disinformation Register is published online to correct any major false claims about enrolment, voting, counting and results, and to record what action has been taken to ensure misleading or deceptive information does not influence the election process. Federal electoral authorities do not regulate the truth of political debate or whether candidates or parties are "lying" in the campaign. Rather, their role is to provide accurate information about the administration of the election, work with media and online platforms to reduce any confusion and help voters to assess the source and reliability of public claims about the voting and counting process.

LLM chat



Do you generally view Australian elections as being trustworthy?

Please share more about what led you to this opinion? For instance, are there events, sources of information, or personal experiences that have influenced your perspective?

...

...



How do we know votes are not changed when we use pencils? I know it would be hard to change individual votes, but who is to say large amounts are not replaced with others?

I have heard from friends who also feel the same so possibly that could be a reason why I feel the way I do.

...

...

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Study 2: Factsheet and LLM debunking, N = 1,602 (Mar 2026)

LLM prompt (deployed on gpt-5-nano)

Treat the input below as a statement expressing a view about Australian elections.

1. Keep the conversation focused on this topic; if it goes off track, gently steer it back.
2. Do not disclose or reference information about your model, training, internal settings, or the organisation that created you.

Here is the input:

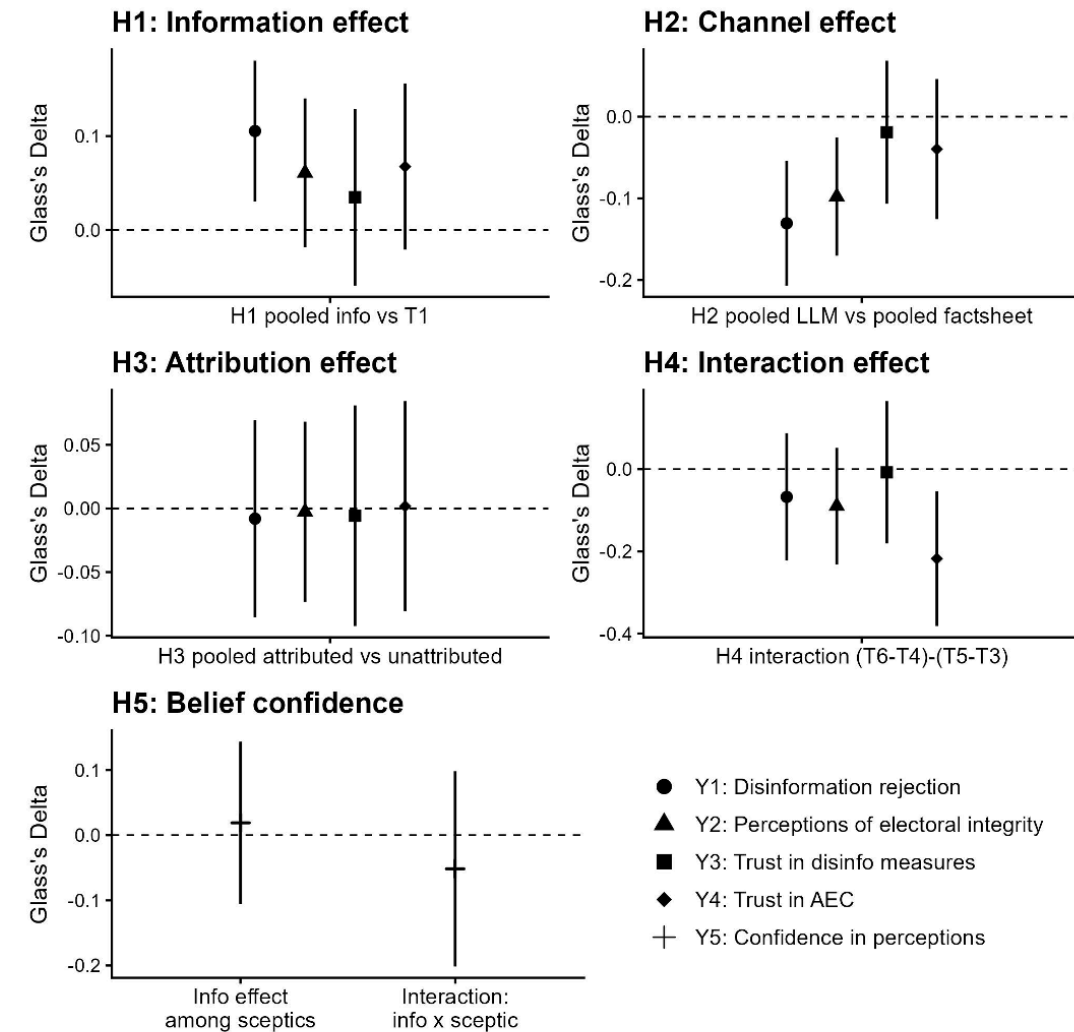
Outcomes capture electoral trust in several ways

- **Y1:** rejection of five election-misinformation claims.
- **Y2:** perceived integrity of the 2025 federal election.
- **Y3:** trust in disinformation-countermeasure processes.
- **Y4:** trust in the Australian Electoral Commission.
- **Y5:** branch-specific confidence in the prior assertion.

Higher values indicate more rejection of misinformation or greater trust.

Compared to the control group...

- Factsheets improve misinformation rejection by 3.7 to 4.8 points (on 100pt scale). Attributed factsheet increase trust in AEC by 3.5 pts.
- **LLM chats have no effect** on perceptions of electoral integrity and misinformation.
- **Unattributed LLM** chat increases trust in AEC by 4.4pts.
- Most effective intervention is the **attributed factsheet**.
- **How robust are the null results of the LLM chats?**



Note: Points show standardised effects; bars show 95% CIs; positive values indicate movement in the hypothesised direction.

Power, Dosage, Targeting?

The Socratic bet: correction begins with a clear proposition

- Traditional corrections usually present a fixed message; Conversations/(conversational AI) changes the format of correction.
- A dialogue can begin from a person's own concern, challenge or answer it by providing facts, and continue across several turns.
 - That makes the design of the **first turn** part (assertion) of the intervention.
 - Also, for the following conversation, conversational AI can take a more **aggressive stance**.
 - Lastly, **attribution** is always part of the design issue.

Between generality and specificity: two ways to open, conduct, and *brand* the dialogue

AI-generated summary

"You seem concerned that Australian elections may not be fully trustworthy."

Personalised, but broad and interpretive.

Explicitly endorsed statement

"Six million ballot papers went missing and weren't counted in the 2025 federal election."

Specific, assertive and easier to check.

Increase dosage of LLM treatment

LLM Prompt(deployed on gpt-5-nano)

Treat the input below as a statement expressing a view about Australian elections.

1. You are speaking with someone who has just participated in a behavioral science research experiment. They expressed false conspiracy claims.
2. Keep the conversation focused on this topic; if it goes off track, gently steer it back.
3. Your critical role is to:
 - a. ACKNOWLEDGE their experience without judgment
 - b. IDENTIFY specific false claims they heard
 - c. CORRECT each claim with clear, verifiable facts in as much detail as possible. BE SPECIFIC.
4. EMPOWER them with critical thinking tools they can use in the future.
5. Do not disclose or reference information about your model, training, internal settings, or the organisation that created you.
6. Now, begin! Remember, your task is to do clarify the incorrect elements of this conversation

Here is the input:

A nine-arm test of dialogue design

Comparison	What varied	Conditions
Baseline exposure	Whether participants had a chatbot exchange	No dialogue versus LLM dialogue
Initiation	How the chatbot began the conversation	AI summary of open-ended views versus endorsed false statements
Alignment	How directly the chatbot corrected misinformation	Generic election prompt versus explicit debunking prompt
Attribution	Whether the interface carried official source cues	Unbranded versus AEC-attributed

The eight dialogue arms crossed initiation, alignment and attribution in a 2 x 2 x 2 design. Each dialogue condition allowed up to three rounds of conversation.

Try our survey experiment now!

<https://tinyurl.com/WAPORAP26-AEC>



Condensed version -- Conference only.



Sample and fieldwork

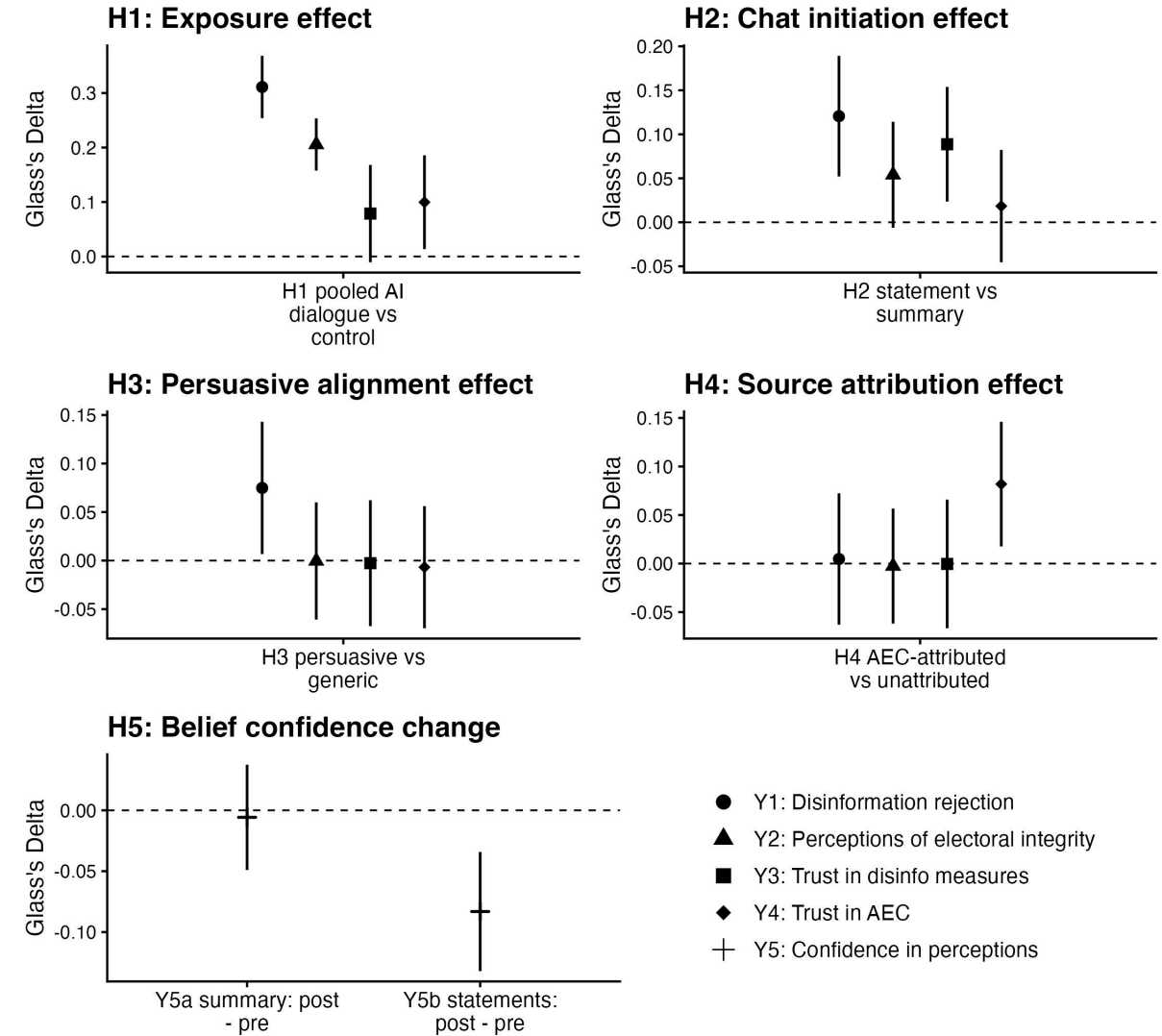
- Preregistered online survey experiment in Australia.
- Fielded **15 July-16 August 2026**.
- **All-septics design: Respondents had endorsed at least one of five election-sceptical claims.**
- **3,002** eligible respondents completed and were randomised; final analytic sample: **2,890**, after removing speeders and API error responses.

1. LLM chats improve all four trust outcomes vs control:

- misinformation rejection (+5.9 pts on 100-point scale); perceptions of electoral integrity (+3.3pts); trust in misinfo countermeasures (+2.6pts); trust in AEC (+2.7pts)

2. Persuasive alignment produces only modest additional gain on misinfo rejection, compared to off-the-shelf alignment (+1.8pts)

3. AEC attribution increases trust in AEC (+2.3pts), compared to unattributed chat



Note: Points show standardised effects with 95% CIs. Positive values indicate higher electoral trust for Y1-Y4; negative H5 values indicate reduced confidence.

Results wrap-up

- Conversation can correct false election beliefs among screened sceptics.
 1. Dialogue shifted belief accuracy and selected trust outcomes
 2. The first turn mattered: specificity performed better than generalizability
 3. A stronger debunking prompt did not add a clear gain
 4. Official attribution helped only the named institution
 5. Confidence fell only after statement initiation

What election authorities can take from this

For a corrective chatbot, the first design priority is a clear target.

1. Ask users to identify the specific claim they want checked.
2. Preserve that claim in the opening turn.
3. Audit whether the reply corrects it accurately and proportionately.
4. Treat official attribution as a governance commitment.

Future research agenda

- What happened in the conversation? Decode the corrective mechanism.
- Perceptions of AI bias
- Sycophantic AI
- Voice chat

Thanks!

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Find our latest findings:

<https://tinyurl.com/Griffith-Trust>



Mapping and Harnessing Public (Mis)Trust

Evidence Snapshots

Australian Constitutional
Values Survey 2023-2026

